



PORTAL TO PANDEMONIUM
Students line up for admissions at Gujarat University; above, a screenshot of the GCAS portal

the state—and then confront this labelling protocol. "It's a communication issue. The government didn't have the foresight to see students may not grasp everything by reading the newspaper ads. These are children who need offline counselling and guidance," says Congress leader and education activist Manish Doshi, a former syndicate member of Gujarat University.

This ended up defeating the very purpose of an online process, which was to eliminate the forbidding logistical bar for students from far corners of the state in accessing good colleges in urban centres. Unstable internet access had already problematised that. The lack of practical detailing and handholding added to the mess. In the end, the digital world ended up creating a different kind of remoteness.

Another flaw is that a student who figures on a merit list, and is duly alerted, must then share an OTP with the allotted college—physically, in person—to confirm admission by the end of the following working day. Any glitch, and the allotment expires. The student must then wait for another merit list. "After every merit list, hundreds of out-of-town students rush to the admission office, but as soon as the clock strikes five in the evening, the portal stops registering. The student and college are face to face, both ready to confirm admission, but both disenabled," says a principal.

Takeaways

- **GCAS, an online system meant to ease admissions, creates chaos across state**
- **After 22 rounds, only 56% undergrad seats were filled. Three more rounds held, but thousands of seats still vacant**
- **State doesn't halt rollout, despite evidence of failure**

TECHNICAL KNOCKOUT

Doubts are being raised even on the system's supposed innate fairness, especially after reports of students with lower grades getting admission while those with higher grades wait. This is compounded by the fact that the data on which colleges have confirmed admissions to which students is not publicly available. Dr Neerja Gupta, vice-chancellor of Gujarat University, says she is unable to access data on how many seats are vacant in colleges affiliated even to her own university! To top it all, the usual complaints of server crashing during peak hours completed the shambolic picture.

As a concept, Gupta endorses the democratic spirit behind GCAS, but says such a high-stakes exercise needed better planning. "Time is everything in the admission process. The official technical team's presence is transient," she says. They didn't even go for a trial run to identify potential issues before the process went live. She recommends that the process be handed over to a nodal college that understands the nuances of the admission process.

But the education department refuses to step back and allow colleges to conclude the process offline, rues Doshi. "The end is not even in sight," he says. A principal foresees a spillover of the chaos to the next semester, as students start applying for a shift to their favoured choice—offline. ■